

Heist Mode:

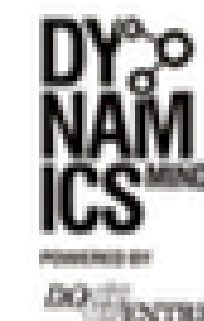
Stealing Game UX Patterns for Better Power Apps

UX · POWER APPS · GAME DESIGN

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Sandra Kiel

Heist Mode: Stealing Game
UX Patterns for Better
App Experiences



Why people return to games?

The 5 main reasons players come back to games



Because it's
fun



Because they
feel progress



Because their
people are there



Because it helps
them switch off



Because it
makes them feel
good about
themselves

People who play the game make themselves capable, strong, and creative, and they feel good about it.

And that matters.

No one has to force them.

No one has to remind them three times.

No one has to explain why it matters.

They come back because the
experience gives them a reason to.

Momentum!

Momentum is the metric nobody talks about in Business

Low Momentum (typical App):

You open the app →
a huge form →
you scroll →
you look for the right section →
you're unsure →
"I'll do it later".

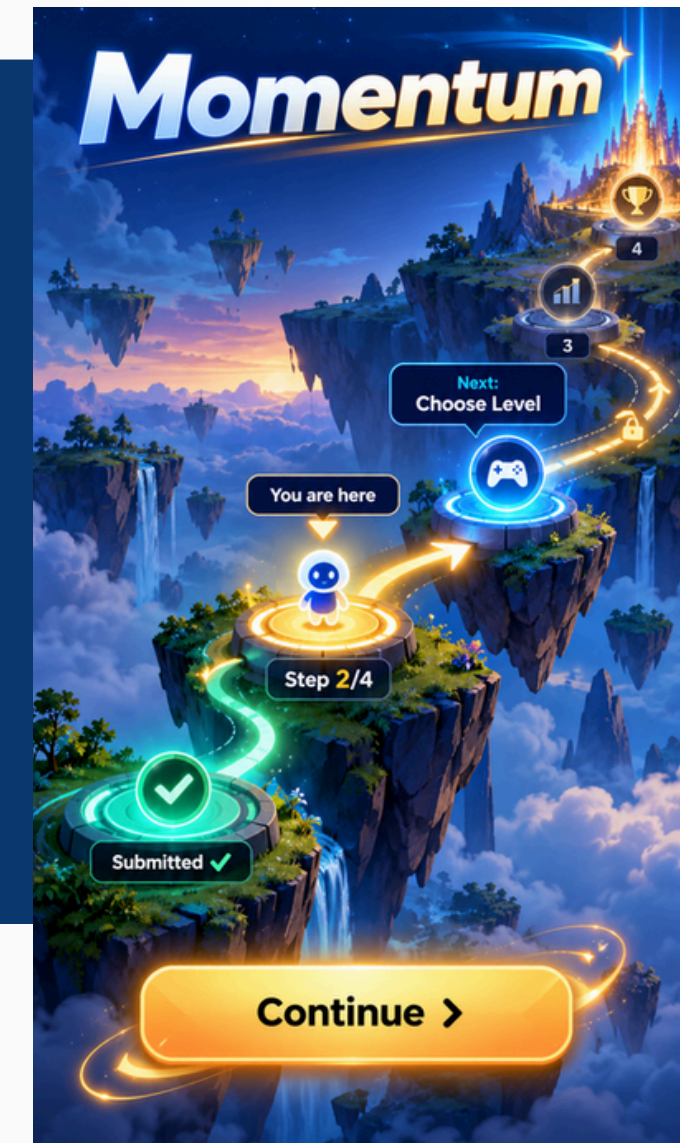
It doesn't happen later.



High Momentum (Game UI Thinking):

You open the game →
you see "Step 1/4" →
"You are here" →
"Next: Choose Level" →
a clear button →
after clicking: "Submit ✓"

You stay in because the next step is obvious.



Momentum = how easy it feels to stick with it and keep going.

**Business apps are often
designed for completion.**

**Games are designed for
return.**



Levels of app experience

Functional



Request Details

Requester Information

First Name: [Text Field] Email: [Text Field]

Last Name: [Text Field]

Department: [Dropdown Menu]

Project Details

Project Name: [Text Field]

Project Code: [Text Field]

Priority: [Dropdown Menu] Start Date: [Text Field] Budget: [Text Field]

Resource Requirements

Resource Type	Qty	Months
Team Member	1	1
Team Member	6	6
Team Member	2	2

Budget Breakdown

Category	Amount
Labor Cost	\$14,000
Tools & Software	\$4,000
Licenses	\$2,000
Materials	\$1,000
Administrative Costs	\$1,000
Contingency	\$1,000
Total	\$30,000

Risk Assessment

List potential risks and how to mitigate them.

Vendor delays; mitigate with early commitments.

Dependencies

List dependencies that may impact this project.

Design system updates; vendor availability.

Stakeholders

List key stakeholders and their roles.

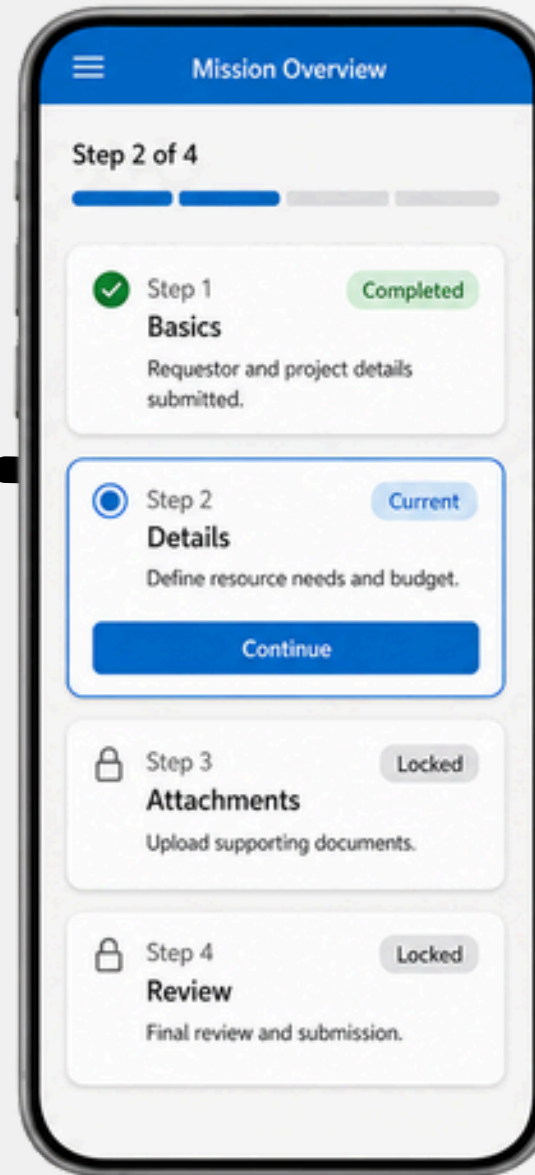
Marketing, IT, Facilities.

Approval Chain

Approver Name	Role
Manager Name	Approval Chain
Director Name	Approval Chain
Finance	Approval Chain
Legal	Approval Chain
Executive Sponsor	Approval Chain

Save Cancel

Motivating



Mission Overview

Step 2 of 4

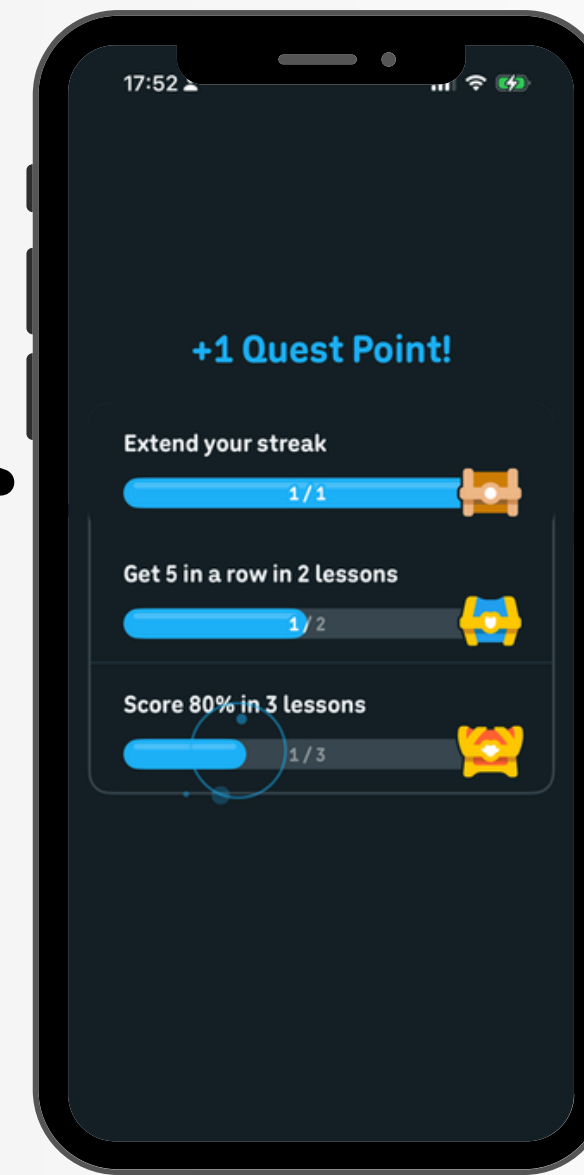
Step 1 Basics Completed
Requestor and project details submitted.

Step 2 Details Current
Define resource needs and budget.
Continue

Step 3 Attachments Locked
Upload supporting documents.

Step 4 Review Locked
Final review and submission.

Gamified



17:52

+1 Quest Point!

Extend your streak
1 / 1

Get 5 in a row in 2 lessons
1 / 2

Score 80% in 3 lessons
1 / 3





Levels of app experience

Functional



Request Details

Requester Information

First Name: Jane
Last Name: Smith
Email: jane.smith@acme.com
Department: Operations

Project Details

Project Name: Office Revamp
Project Code: OFF-2024
Priority: Medium
Start Date: 01/20/2024
Budget: \$50,000

Resource Requirements

Resource Type	Qty	Months
Team Member	1	1
Team Member	6	6
Team Member	2	2

Budget Breakdown

Category	Amount
Labor Cost	\$14,000
Tools & Software	\$4,000
Licenses	\$2,000
Materials	\$1,000
Administrative Costs	\$1,000
Contingency	\$1,000
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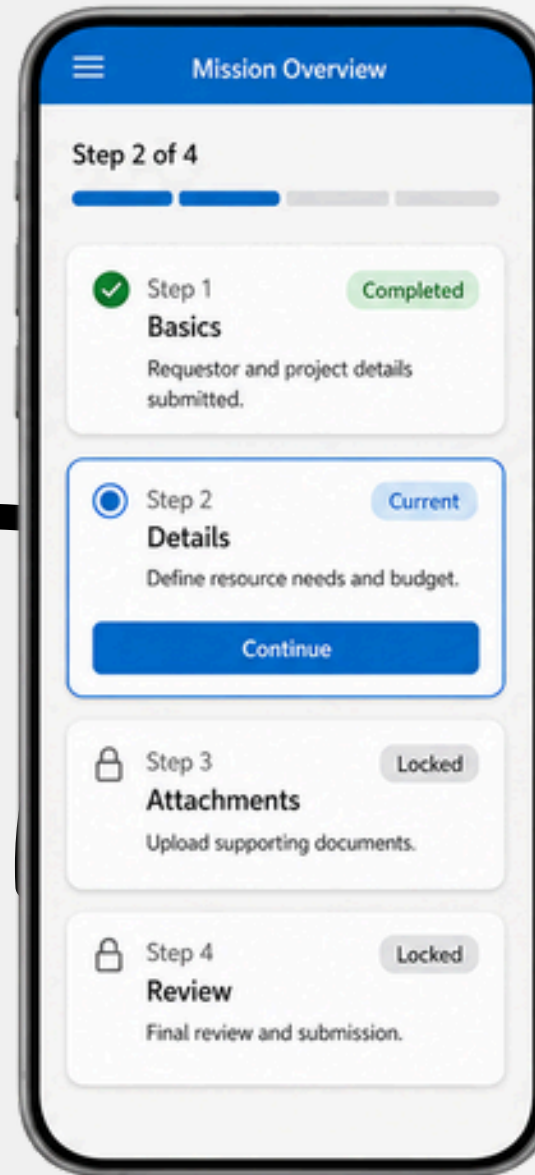
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Motivating



Mission Overview

Step 2 of 4

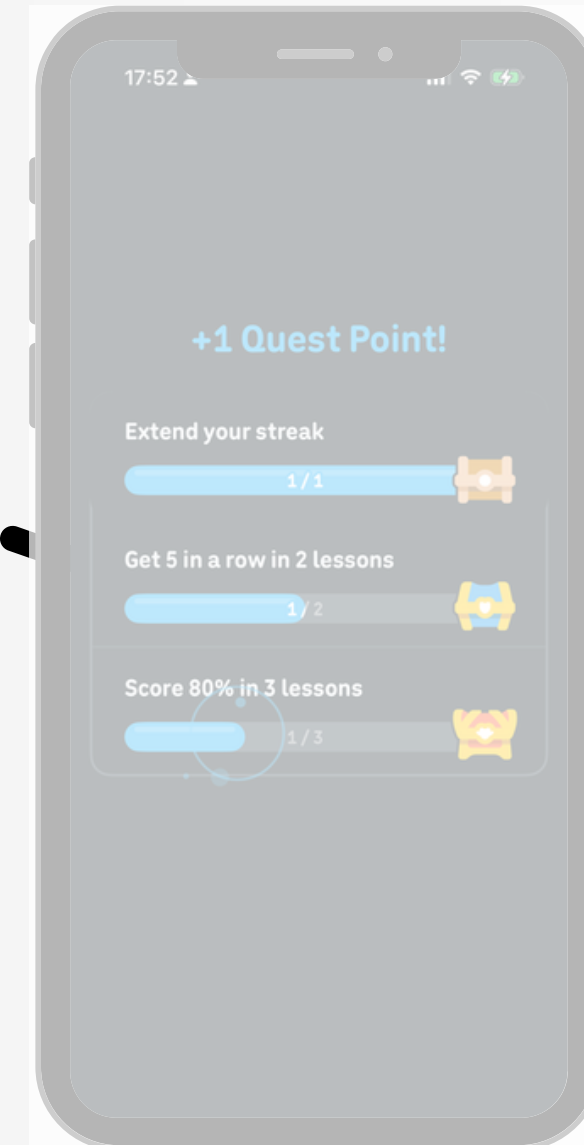
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Gamified



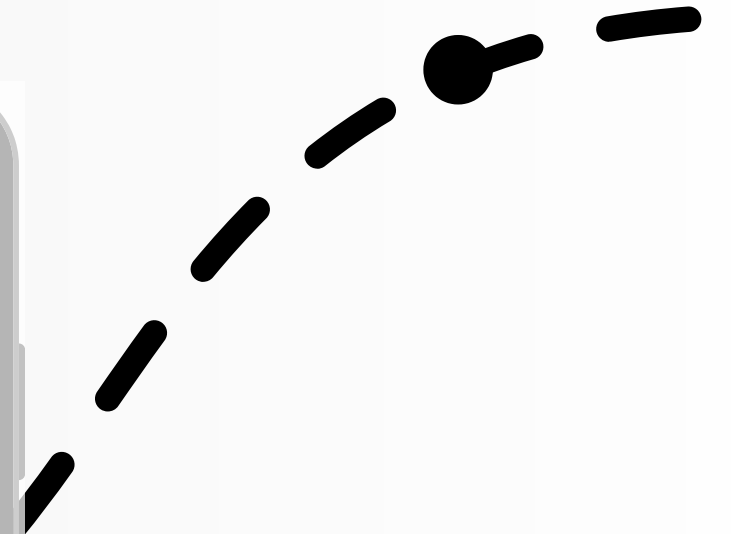
17:52

+1 Quest Point!

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1 / 1

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1 / 2

Score 80% in 3 lessons
1 / 3



The 5 Fixes that actually matter.

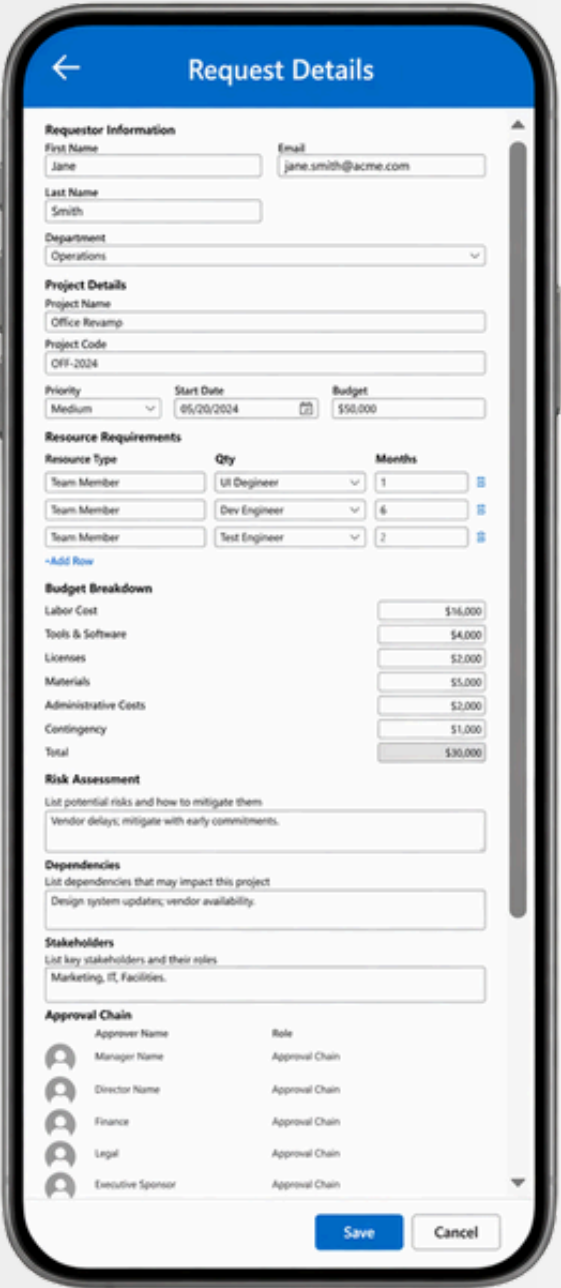


Each fix is small enough to actually ship. Together, they fundamentally change how a business app *feels*.

Stop the Scroll of Doom

Before: Endless Scroll

One giant screen
feels overwhelming
and directionless



Request Details

Requestor Information

First Name: Jane, Email: jane.smith@acme.com, Last Name: Smith, Department: Operations

Project Details

Project Name: Office Revamp, Project Code: OFF-2024, Priority: Medium, Start Date: 05/20/2024, Budget: \$50,000

Resource Requirements

Resource Type	Qty	Months
Team Member	UI Designer	1
Team Member	Dev Engineer	6
Team Member	Test Engineer	2

Budget Breakdown

Labor Cost	\$16,000
Tools & Software	\$4,000
Licenses	\$2,000
Materials	\$5,000
Administrative Costs	\$2,000
Contingency	\$1,000
Total	\$30,000

Risk Assessment

List potential risks and how to mitigate them.

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Dependencies

List dependencies that may impact this project.

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Stakeholders

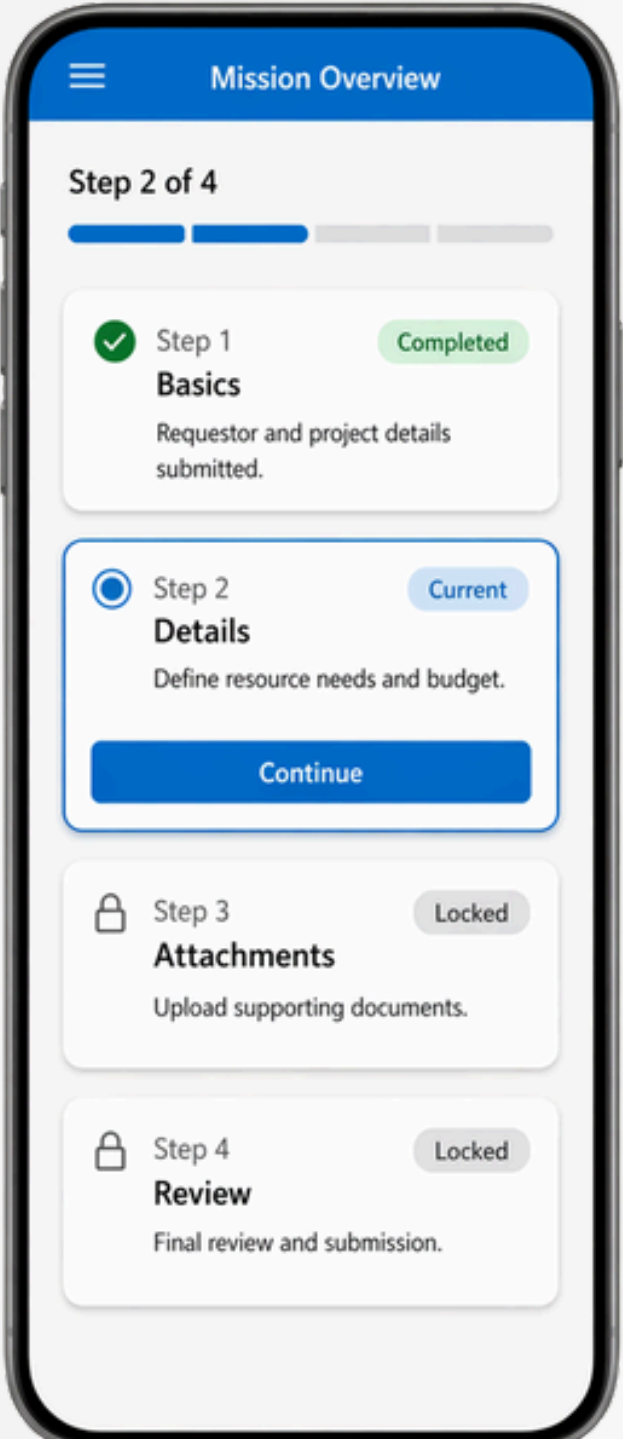
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Mission Overview

Step 2 of 4

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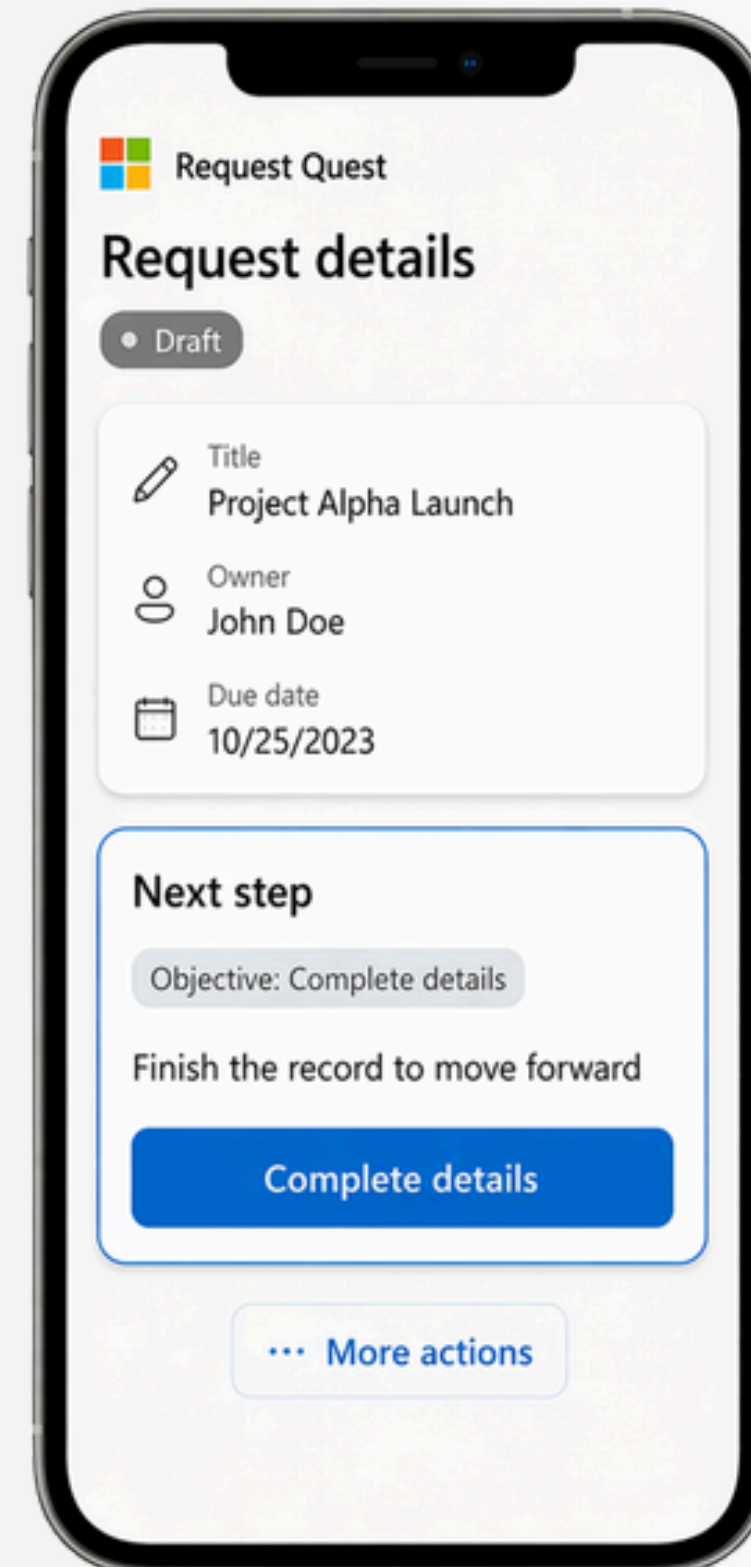
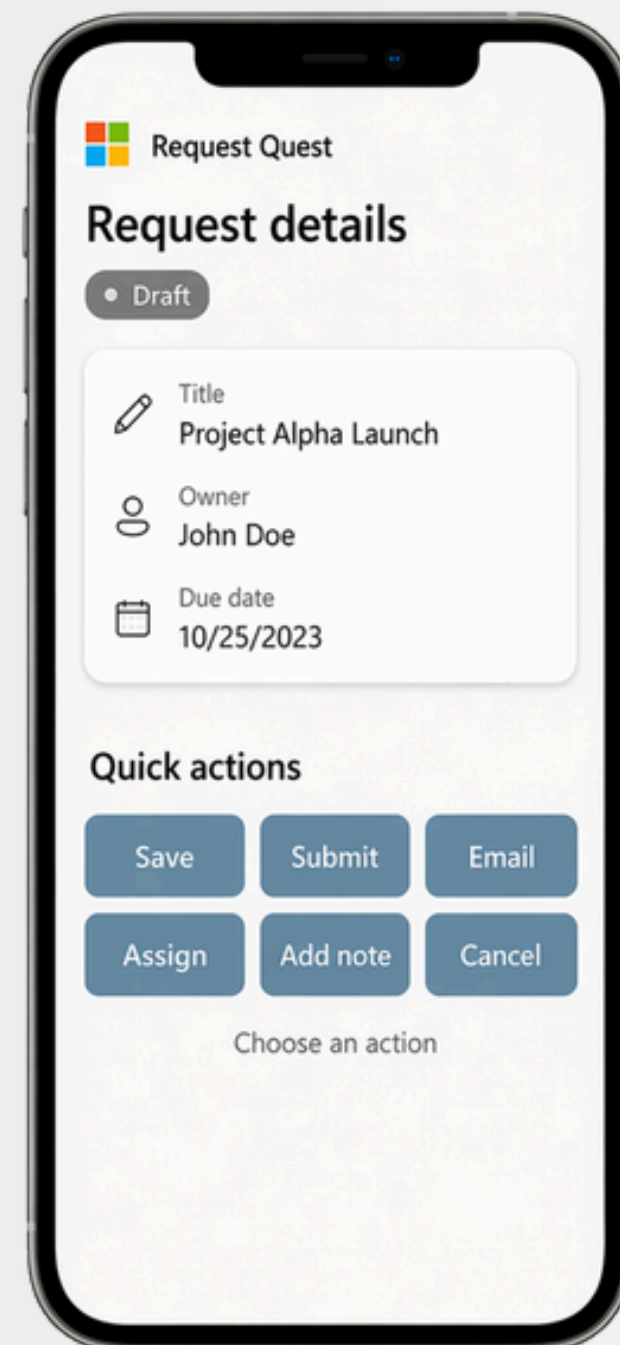
After: Chunked Steps

Clear steps with
progress and
completion moments

Stop the Button Panic

Before: CTA Chaos

When everything looks equally important, every click feels risky.



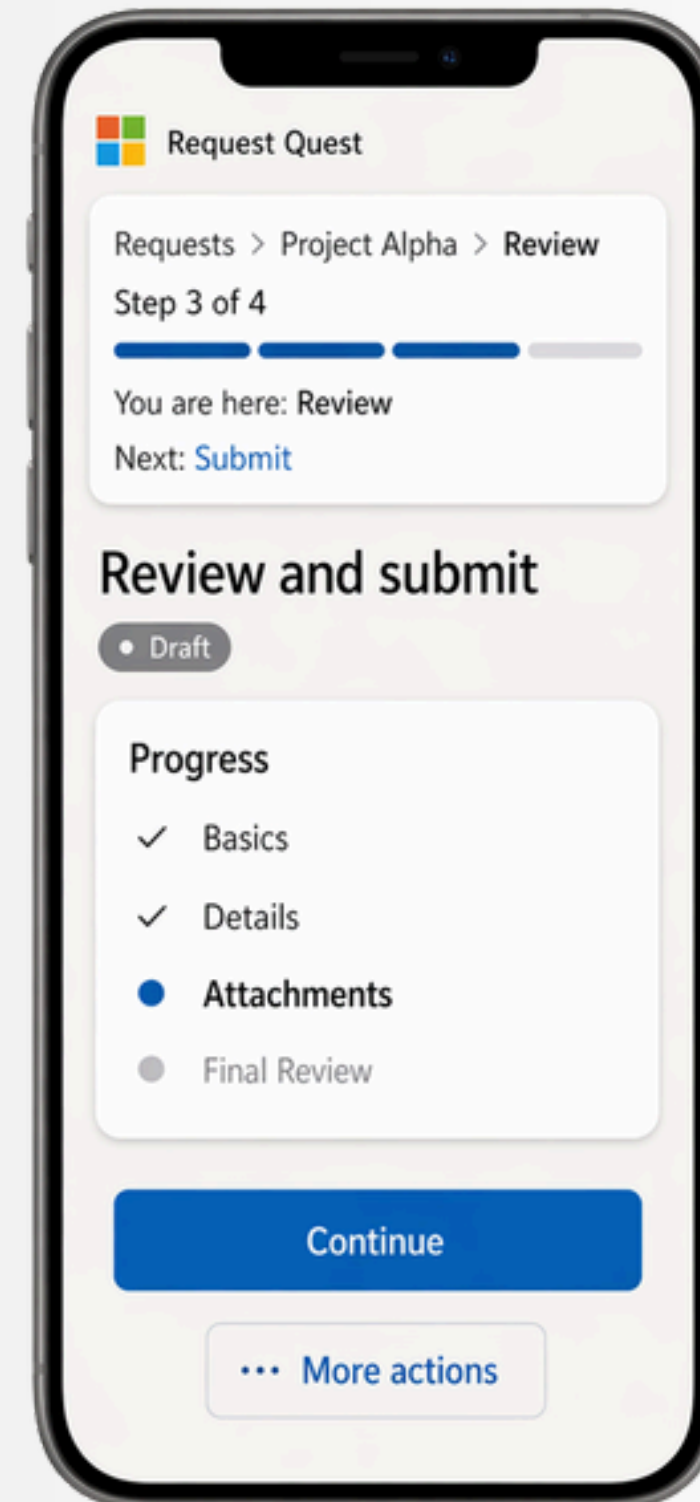
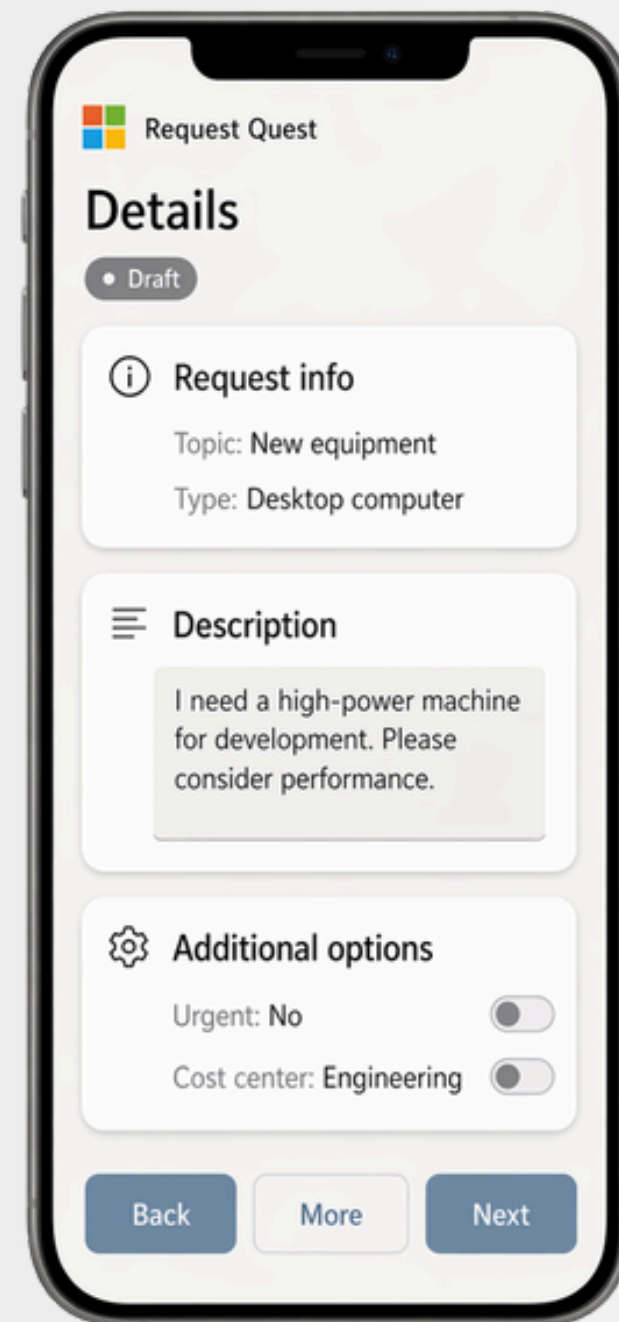
After: One clear next step

Primary action clearly highlighted. Secondary actions hidden under "More Actions".

Stop the **Lost Moment**

Before: Mystery navigation

No breadcrumbs, no progress, no orientation.
The pause moment arrives
– and users drop out.



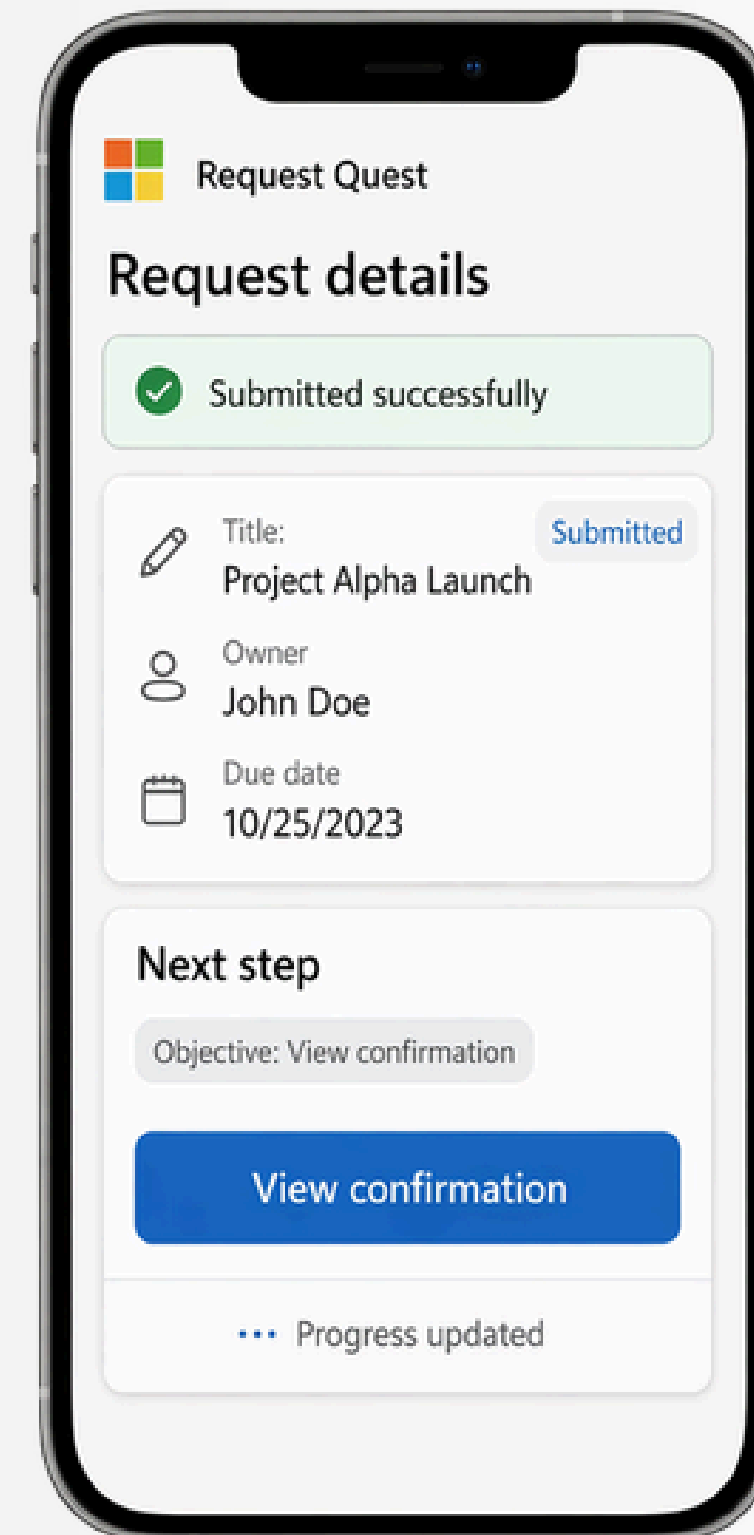
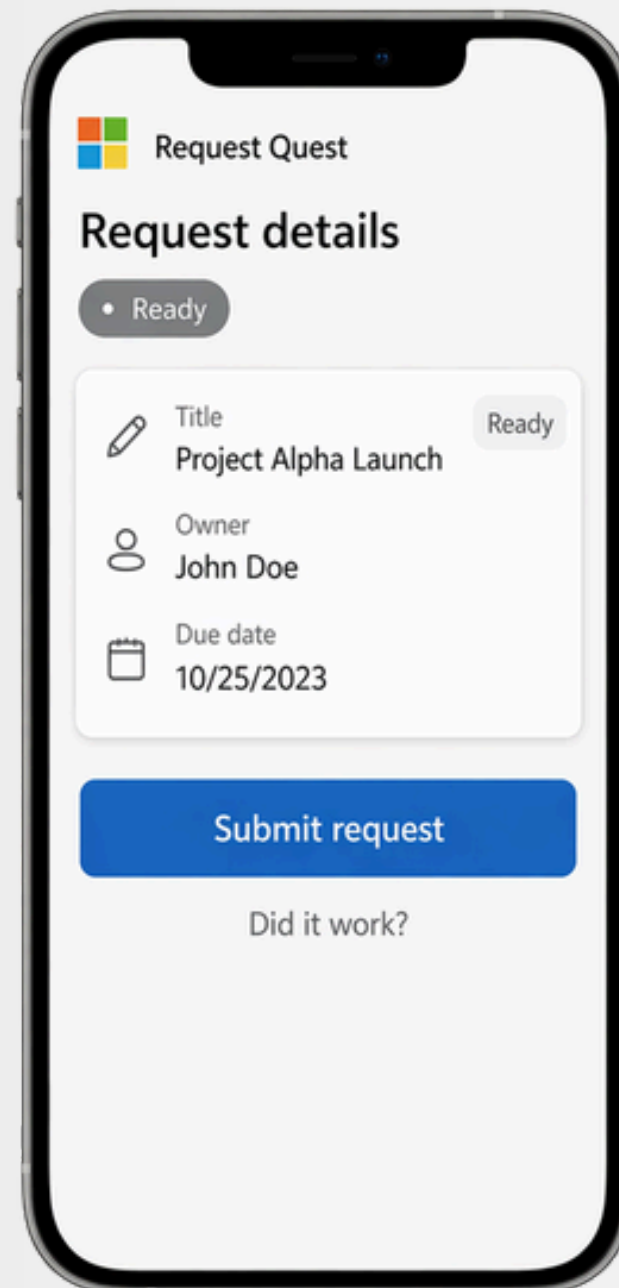
After: HUD Navigation

Orientation + Objective +
Progress at a glance. Users
always know where they are
and what comes next.

Stop the **Silent Click**

Before: No Feedback

A user clicks. Then waits.
Then wonders. Then clicks again. No visible loading.
No confirmation. No status change. No trust.



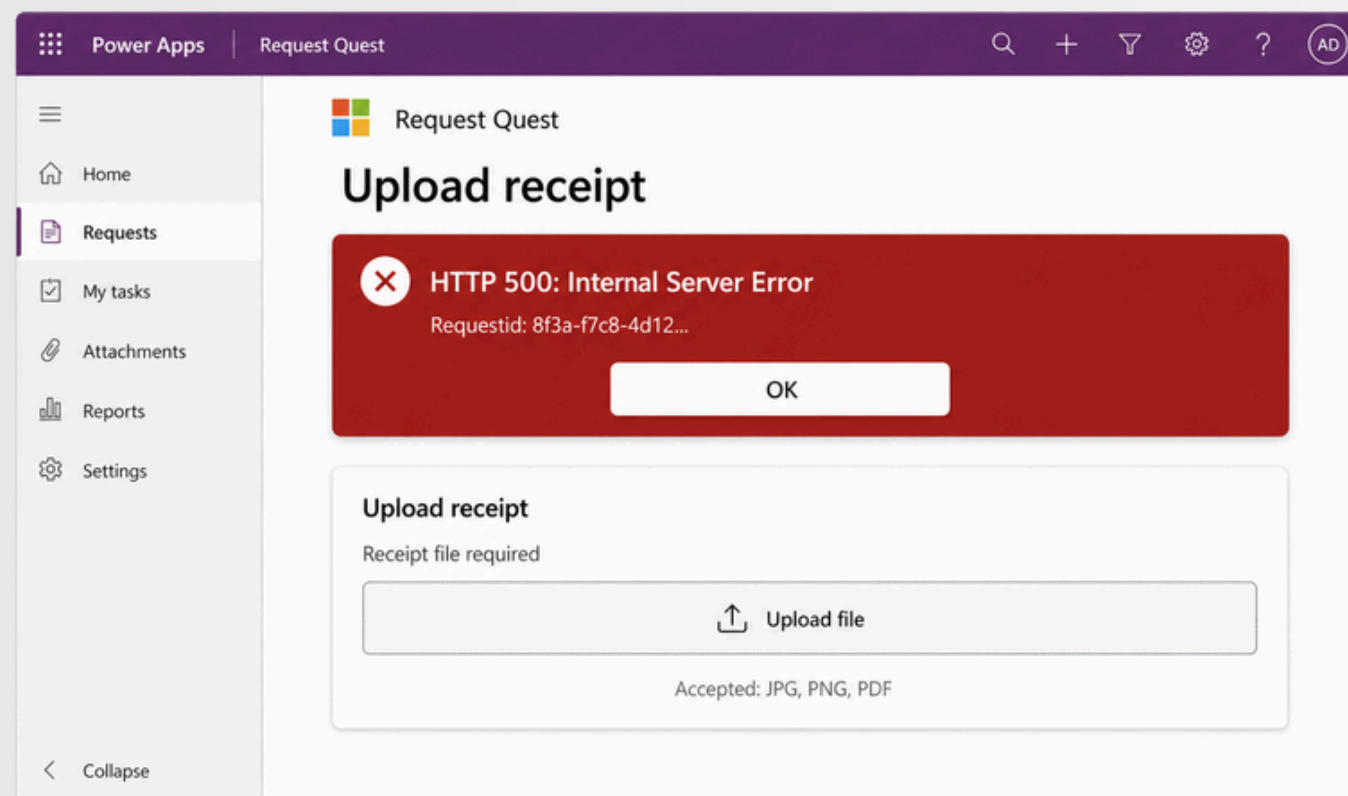
After: Micro Feedback

A clear message with context: What happened?
What should be done? No generic "Error occurred".

Stop the **Error Punishment**

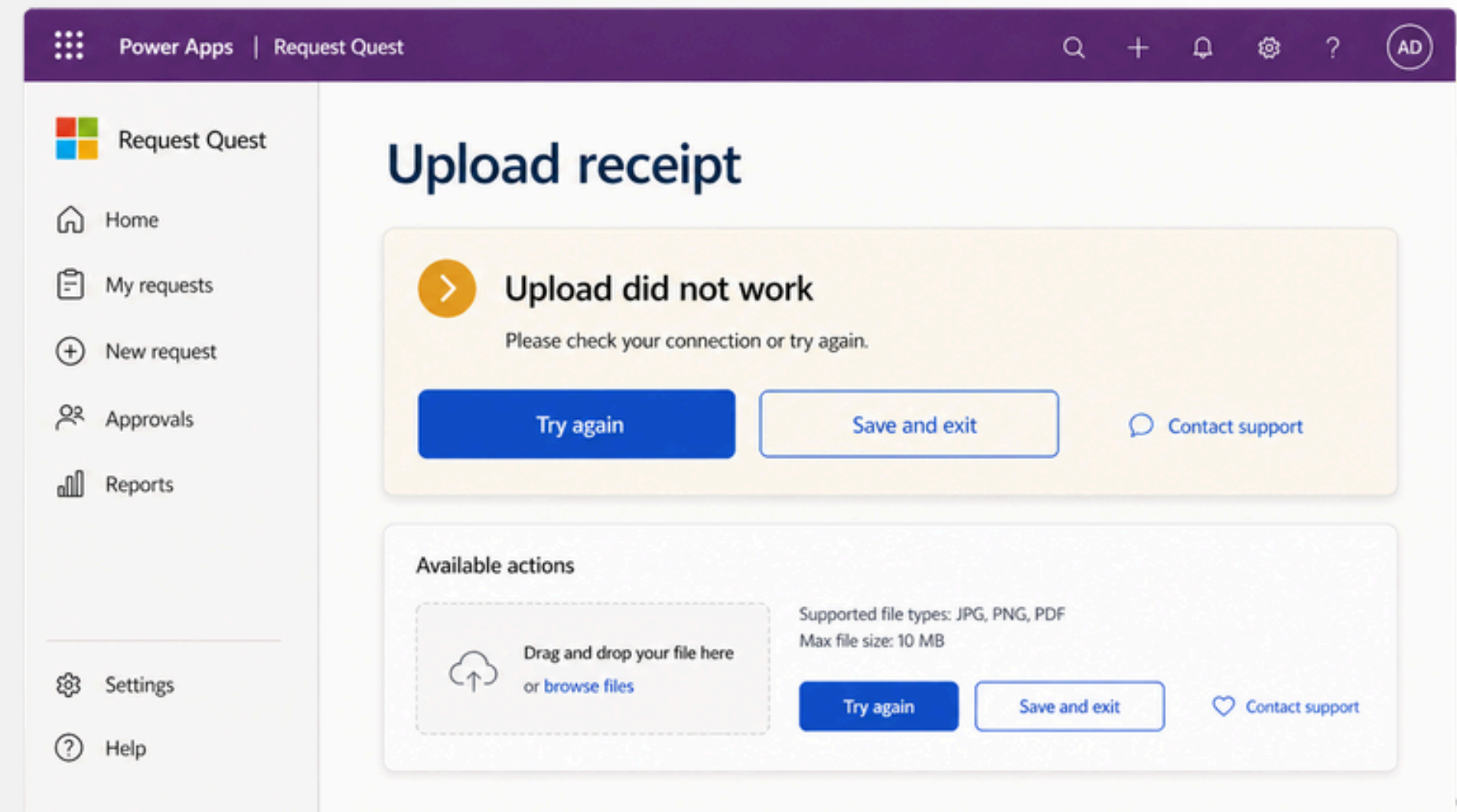
Before: Punishment

Technical error message, no way out, no next step. Users feel guilty – and give up.



After: Recovery Path

Human language, clear action: "Please check field X." + "Try again" button. Mistakes should lead back into the flow, not cause embarrassment.



From **friction-heavy** to momentum-friendly

Flat	→	Guided
Silent	→	Responsive
Overwhelming	→	Structured
Risky	→	Reassuring
Punishing	→	Finishable



“I know what to do **NEXT**”

The first Level is not delight.

The first Level is clarity.

Momentum friendly UX first. Gamification second.

Every app benefits from

- Better orientation
- Better pacing
- Better feedback
- Better recovery
- Stronger next-step logic

Not every app needs

- Mascots
- Streaks
- Reward loops
- Celebration mechanics

BUT

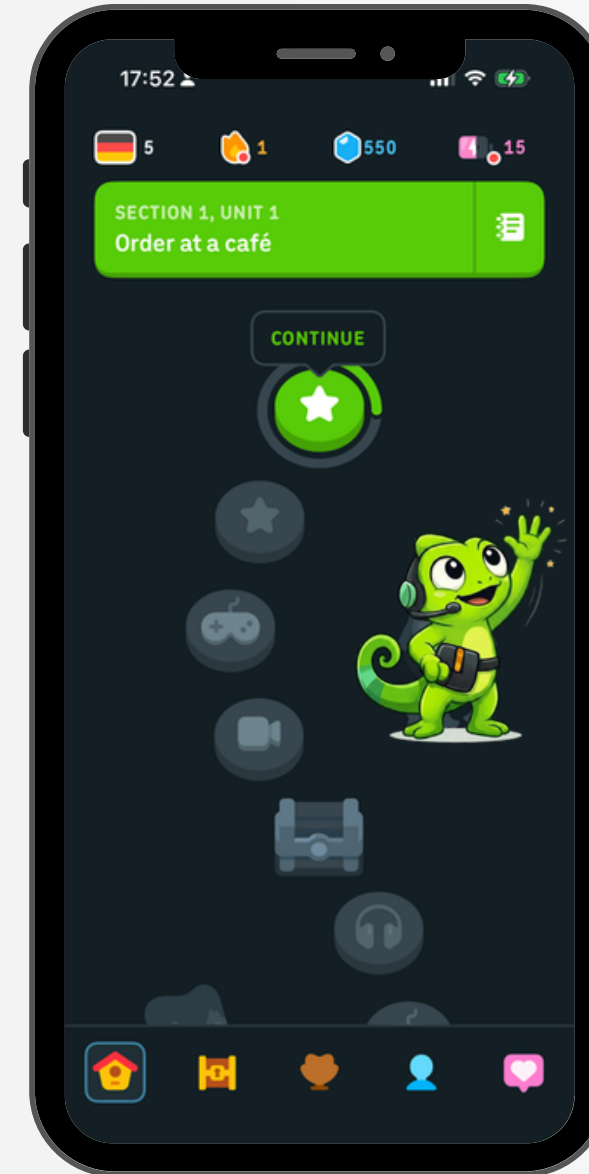
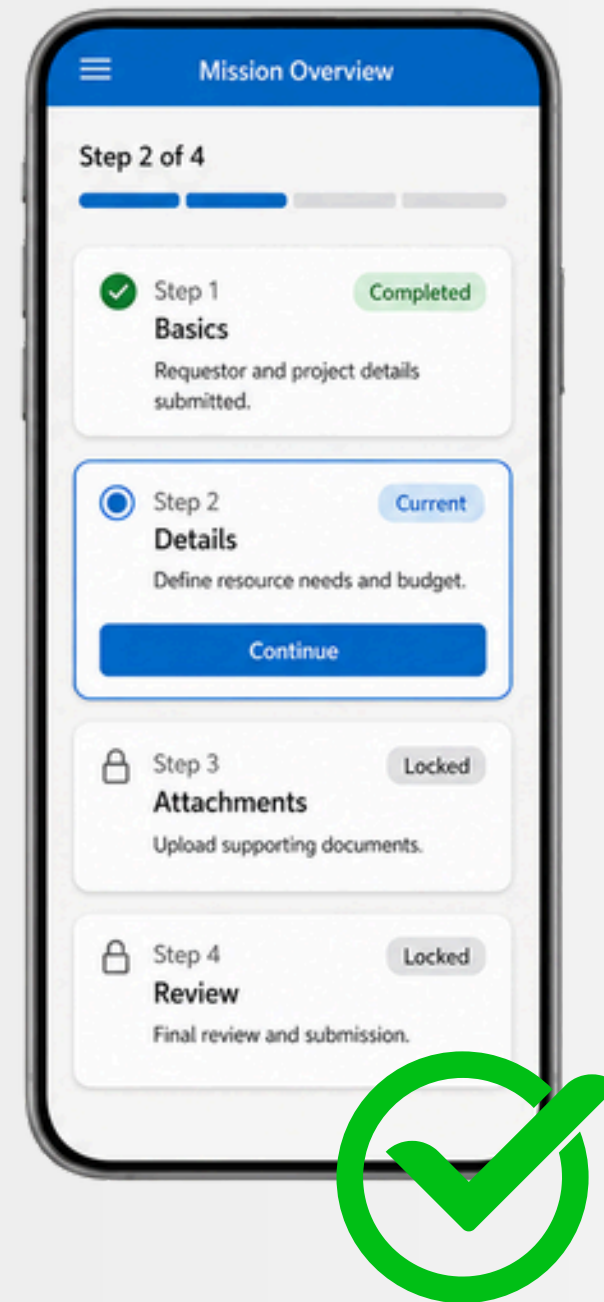
The Next Level:

Momentum-friendly UX to Game UX

We optimized

- Progress
- Completion
- Action
- Orientation
- Feedback

The first Level is clarity.



...with Game UX we can add

- Purpose (hero)
- Rewards (badges)
- Challenges (streaks)
- Individualization (who/where I am)

These elements tap into intrinsic motivation and create sustainable habits.

Game UX adds

The Hero

A guide character makes the app feel approachable and gives clear next steps.



Individualization

Let users choose a role or goal so the journey feels personal.



Streaks

Creates a rhythm (daily habit)
Prevents "spam completing"
Makes return behavior predictable



Badges

Badges should not reward random clicks. They should reward meaningful progress.



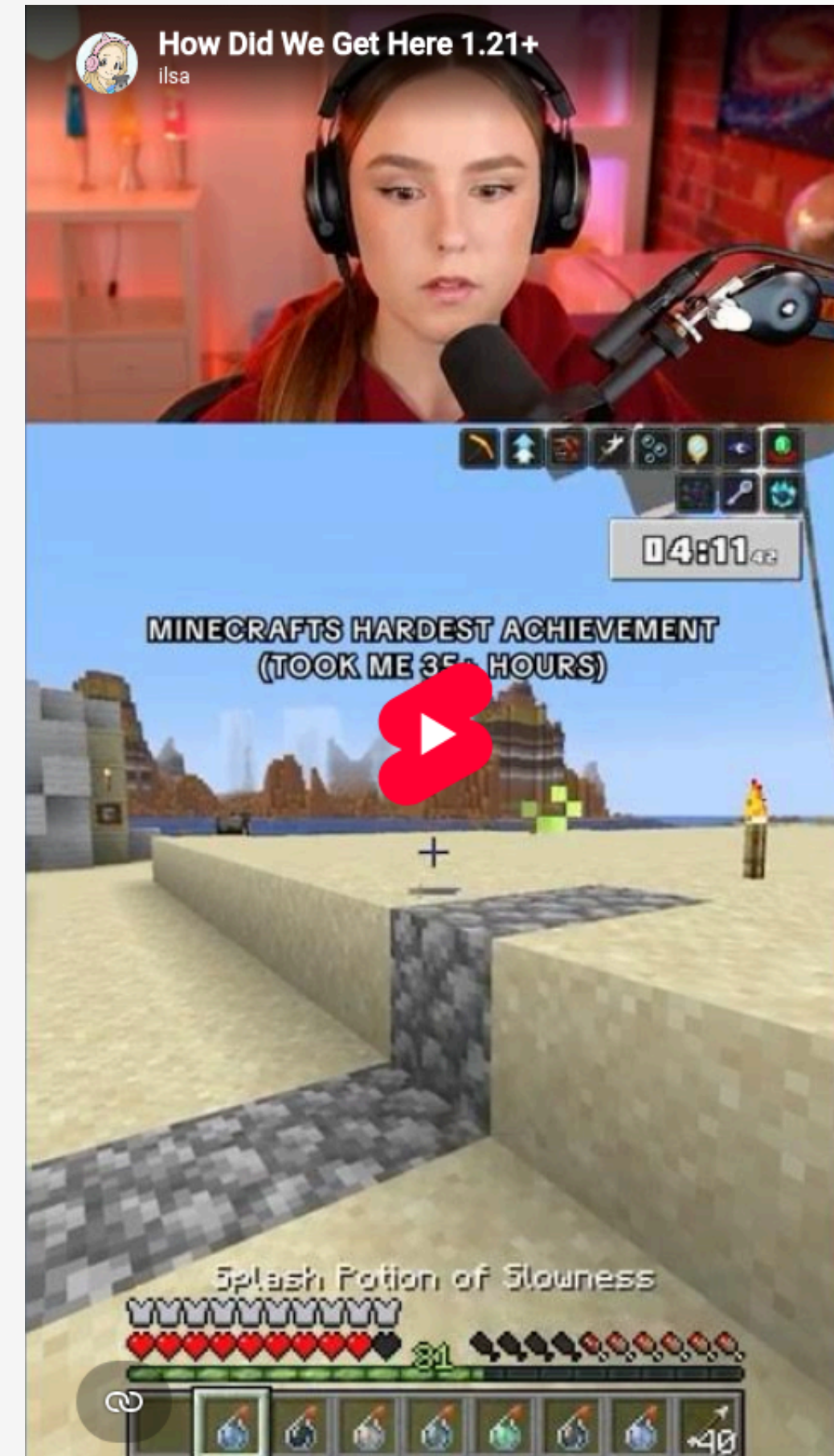
Demo Mode

Last word about Badges

What Minecraft's "How Did We Get Here?" teaches us about motivation

- It is difficult – you do not earn it by accident
- It feels meaningful – it proves effort, planning, and mastery
- It is memorable – even the name tells a story
- It is social – people want to share the moment

Great badges create emotion, not just completion
A badge is not a sticker. It is a signal



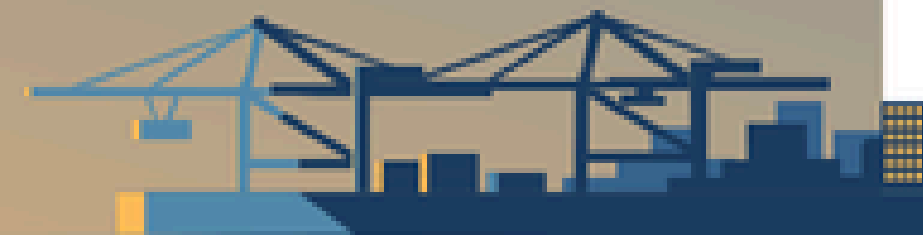
“

Build for more than
completion.

Build for return.

Sandra Kiel

2026, Baltic Summit



**PLEASE RATE THIS
SESSION IN THE APP**

run_oevents

